



Almost 250,000 displaced Sierra Leoneans were resettled or had returned to their areas of origin by the end of 2002, according to UN figures, officially ending the situation of internal displacement in the country and further consolidating its recovery after more than a decade of devastating civil war. As in Liberia, the sustainability of return and resettlement was in many cases questionable with some NGOs in particular criticising the whole process as being politically driven ahead of elections in 2002. While peace and security have continued to hold, even with the departure of the remaining UNAMSIL peacekeepers at the end of 2005, this risks being jeopardised by a number of unresolved issues – including extreme poverty, high unemployment, corruption and inequitable distribution of resources. Indeed some of these issues may be brought into yet sharper focus as political tensions rise ahead of national elections to be held in 2007. The UN Integrated Office in Sierra Leone (UNIOSIL) was established at the beginning of 2006 with a broad mandate that includes building national capacity for conflict prevention and preparing for free and fair elections in 2007.

Gross human rights abuses

Sierra Leone's 11 year civil war was characterised by widespread and systematic sexual violence and rape, as well as mutilation of civilians – many of them while fleeing. Lack of adequate protection of internally displaced populations was a major cause for concern throughout the conflict. Large parts of the country had no law enforcement system for several years, and while civilians outside rebel-held areas received some protection from civil defence militia and the West African ECOMOG forces, this was clearly inadequate. The atrocities meted out on civilians by Revolutionary United Front (RUF) rebels during the January 1999 attack on Freetown were just one example of this failure.

As in Liberia, rebels in Sierra Leone regularly abducted children, either to fight in combat or as domestic and sex slaves. According to Save the Children-UK, children constituted about 60 per cent of IDPs in Sierra Leone and as many as 1.8 million children may at some time have been displaced since the outbreak of the war in 1991 – making them extremely vulnerable. More than 5,000 parents reported their children missing just in the wake of the rebel attack on Freetown in January 1999.

Since the end of Sierra Leone's civil war in 2002 and the subsequent resettlement of hundreds of thousands of IDPs, the country has started to recover from more than a decade of trauma and devastation. The RUF was officially disarmed, and a UN-mandated Special Court indicted several people for war crimes, including Charles Taylor. The UN peacekeeping force, UNAMSIL, finally withdrew at the end of 2005 after successfully contributing to the restoration of peace and security in the country.

Yet the overall situation remains fragile and challenges remain to ensure the consolidation of state authority and maintain security throughout the country, particularly in border areas. Economic recovery has been very limited, with poverty, high unemployment, and continuing corruption and mismanagement within the government all presenting urgent challenges. Frustration especially among young demobilised fighters who lack sustainable reintegration opportunities constitutes a major risk to continuing stability, more so in light of reports of continuing cross-border flows of diamonds, arms and mercenaries. And while many of the egregious human rights violations that caused or resulted from the civil war are no longer taking place, there is still not a general culture of respect for basic human rights. While the Truth and Reconciliation Commission completed its mandate in 2004, the government has yet to prepare a comprehensive action plan for implementing the recommendations.

Unresolved humanitarian needs

In stark parallel to the current situation in Liberia, many internally displaced Sierra Leoneans returned to areas with no basic infrastructure or social services in place, creating acute humanitarian needs and causing some resettlers to drift back to urban areas. Resettlement assistance was only provided for registered IDPs, not for the many thousands who were either unregistered, or who did not wish to be resettled for various reasons, including security fears. Homelessness in the capital Freetown has become a serious problem.

While the agriculture sector has been recovering since the end of the conflict in 2002, with food production gradually moving towards pre-war levels, food security is still weak particularly in eastern and southern areas to where many IDPs returned. WFP food aid for vulnerable populations is still required. Access to food is restricted in many cases by high prices, rampant unemployment and overall lack of economic opportunity, as well as poor infrastructure. Major rehabilitation of the education and health care sectors is also still needed.

When does displacement end?

While some hailed Sierra Leone's resettlement process as a success story in which the wishes of internally displaced people themselves prevailed, others insisted it was a highly flawed and politically driven process.

President Ahmad Tejan Kabbah first took office in 1996 in war-time elections, was toppled in a military coup one year later, and was subsequently reinstated with help from West African peacekeepers and British troops. At the beginning of 2002, with a large UN mission deployed across the country and disarmament completed, Kabbah declared the war to be officially over – just four months ahead of presidential elections that won him another five year term in office. By this time resettlement was proceeding at full speed. Displaced Sierra Leoneans were resettled in accordance with the national government's Resettlement Strategy, which applied to IDPs as well as refugees and ex-combatants with their dependants, and was meant to apply only when resettlement areas were "sufficiently safe to allow for the return of displaced people in safety and dignity". UNHCR was one of numerous agencies that helped to plan and implement the strategy, aiming to harmonise the resettlement of refugees and IDPs. Both groups were offered resettlement packages, which included a two-month food ration, household utensils, plastic sheeting, and in some cases, transportation. Some 220,000 registered IDPs were resettled in several phases in 2001 and 2002. Many more returned home spontaneously. Officially, at least, this left no more IDPs in Sierra Leone.



Remains of a RUF rebel in burnt out house, Makeni-Kono road, Sierra Leone, 1997 (Claudia McGoldrick)

Not surprisingly, the resettlement process raised some thorny issues – all of which may be applied to the ongoing process in Liberia. Firstly, nobody could be sure of the real number of IDPs in the country since during a decade of conflict there were always large numbers of unregistered IDPs. Only registered IDPs were eligible for assistance in the camps, and for resettlement packages. With registration itself often unreliable, it was reasonable to assume that there was still an unknown number of IDPs who were not recognised and would not be assisted to return home.



Displaced girls who have undergone female genital mutilation as part of their initiation into the secret 'Bondo Society': Grafton camp, near Freetown, Sierra Leone, 1997. The practice of female genital mutilation on sometimes very young girls – which raised serious protection concerns in IDP camps – remains widespread today
(Claudia McGoldrick)

Secondly, there were also many IDPs who did not wish to be resettled for various reasons. Some were traumatised, some had security fears related to their areas of origin, some had lost their coping mechanisms and had become dependent on camp life, while others were unwilling to return to areas where they knew there was a lack of infrastructure and basic services. Many had become urbanised in the capital, Freetown, adding to a growing problem of homelessness. NGO sources in Sierra Leone privately reported that about 10,000-20,000 "unofficial" IDPs remained, mostly in urban areas. Since one of the principles of the government's resettlement strategy was to discourage dependency on humanitarian aid and prolonged displacement when areas of return were declared safe, there was little if any assistance available for "residual" IDPs.

Another contentious issue was that some IDPs may have been resettled to unsafe areas. The declaration of areas as "safe for resettlement" – the main factor in effectively ending displacement – was based on a number of criteria spelled out in the government's resettlement strategy. These criteria included the complete absence of hostilities, unhindered and safe access of humanitarian workers and sizeable spontaneous return movements. While the entire country was eventually declared safe for resettlement, concern was expressed in some cases that certain areas were prematurely classified as safe, or that established criteria were not properly applied, especially in light of the volatile situation in Liberia. The downsizing and eventual withdrawal of the UN peacekeeping force, UNAMSIL, heightened anxieties for some. Allegations were also made that insufficient or even misleading information was given to displaced people about conditions in their areas of origin.

A further cause for concern was that inadequate resettlement packages, combined with a chronic lack of shelter and basic services in areas of return, caused many IDPs to return once again to urban areas. Plans for

community rehabilitation programmes had in many cases not yet been developed, partly due to insufficient donor funding.

NGOs were among the harshest critics of the government-led resettlement programme. MSF claimed that the government, with the UN, practically forced people to return – ahead of elections and ahead of the planting season in order to avoid food aid dependence for another agricultural season; that in many cases return could not be described as voluntary because IDPs were not given the information to make an informed decision; that inadequate support during both the transit and rehabilitation phases meant that IDPs were returning in neither safety or dignity as required by the UN Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement; and that in some cases resettlement was taking place to areas considered by the UN as too dangerous for its own staff. While the UN acknowledged that numerous challenges had arisen during the resettlement process, which needed to be urgently addressed, it also said that the MSF report to some extent focused on specific issues out of context, thereby misrepresenting the full reality of the situation. However, various other NGOs were also critical of the enormous security, political and socio-economic pressures faced by IDPs in their “voluntary” return home.

Key recommendations to the government:

- Support income-generating activities, including job creation, in key return areas to help ensure successful reintegration for both returnees and ex-combatants
- Focus on rehabilitation of rural infrastructure in key return areas where food security is particularly weak
- Help ensure the sustainability of return by giving sustained attention to the provision of critical services, mainly education, health and sanitation
- Prepare a comprehensive plan for implementing the recommendations of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission